Are the People of the *Mahābhārata* Real? A Pre-Registered Record-Linkage Test Against the Vedic Corpus

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***Abstract*—Whether the people of the *Mahābhārata* existed is usually argued case by case, from belief or from silence. We replace the argument with a test. Every person in the epic's main lineages and embedded stories ($n = 107$) was compared with every person in the older Vedic corpus as catalogued in the *Vedic Index of Names and Subjects* ($n = 2{,}051$ person records). The method combines four published approaches: oral-tradition criticism (Vansina, Henige) to justify the Vedic texts as an independent witness; Mykytiuk's identifying-mark criteria for matching a textual person with an external attestation; Fellegi–Sunter probabilistic record linkage with frequency-based weights to score the marks; and a Bayesian posterior mapped onto Mykytiuk's grades. A protocol fixing assumptions, rules and five "battle tests" was committed before any result was seen; every later change is recorded as a numbered amendment. The first version failed its false-positive test (1.3% against a 1% limit). Version 3, which uses a clean digital transcription of the Index, requires the Vedic text to state the same kind of relationship as the epic, and treats tribes and conflicting roles as disqualifying, passes all pre-set tests: 21 matches against at most 11 in 1,000 permutations ($p = 0.001$), 0.48% false positives over 219,343 wrong-name pairs, and 7 of 9 known identities recovered. Against a full hand review it reaches 0.76 precision and 0.84 recall, and 0.95 precision when only identity (not historicity) is judged. A blind second review agreed with the first on every identity decision (Cohen's $\kappa = 1.00$; $\kappa = 0.77$ when legendary figures are separated), and every relationship on which a verdict depends was checked against the Critical Edition. The results are asymmetric. The generation *after* the war is securely attested: Janamejaya Pārikṣita, his three brothers and his priest Indrota appear in the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa together with the same expiation episode the epic tells. Earlier Kuru figures are real Vedic names re-arranged into a new genealogy, and Rigvedic tribes became brothers. The war generation itself—the Pāṇḍavas, the Kauravas, Bhīṣma, Droṇa, Karṇa and Draupadī—has no independent attestation.**

***Index Terms*—Record linkage, entity resolution, Fellegi–Sunter model, computational history, digital humanities, pre-registration, Mahābhārata, Vedic literature, oral tradition, prosopography.**

I. Introduction

THE *Mahābhārata*, the longest surviving epic, names hundreds of kings, priests and warriors and arranges them in detailed genealogies. Whether these people existed is one of the most contested questions in South Asian history. Public debate often reduces it to two positions: that the epic is a record of real events, or that it is literature with no historical content. Scholarly work has been more careful but has proceeded case by case, without an explicit, repeatable standard of evidence [1]–[3].

This paper asks a narrower question that can be tested: *which people of the Mahābhārata can be identified, with stated confidence, with people named in older and independent sources?* It does not ask whether the war happened, when it happened, or whether the epic's story is true. Identity is a precondition for every one of those later questions, and it is the one question for which a suitable independent witness exists.

That witness is the Vedic corpus. Its texts are older than the epic text; they were memorised with interlocking recitation patterns that make them unusually stable; and they mention kings and priests incidentally, as patrons and authorities in ritual manuals rather than as heroes of a narrative. Witzel described the Vedic texts as "tape recordings" of their period that "we can use as basis for judging the less strict tradition of the Epics" [1]. This paper turns that remark into a procedure.

A. Contributions

1) A **combined identification method** that joins oral-tradition source criticism [4], [5], Mykytiuk's identifying-mark criteria [6], [7], Fellegi–Sunter record linkage with value-specific weights [8]–[11], and Bayesian grading.
2) A **pre-registered protocol** with five battle tests—a permutation null, a large-scale false-positive test, known-identity recall, parameter sensitivity, and clerical review—and a public record of every amendment, including the failures that motivated them.
3) **Two reproducible datasets**: the epic's people coded only from the epic, and every person record in the Vedic Index [13] parsed automatically from the Cologne digital transcription [14].
4) A **double review** with inter-rater agreement and a verse-level check of the epic side against the Critical Edition.

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5) **Substantive findings**: a securely attested post-war court, a re-arranged pre-war genealogy, tribes turned into kin, and an unattested war generation.

II. Background and Related Work

A. The Texts and Their Relative Age

The Ṛgveda is conventionally dated to the second half of the second millennium BCE; the later Saṃhitās and the Brāhmaṇas, in which most named kings and priests appear, to the early first millennium BCE [1]. The *Mahābhārata* text took shape over several centuries around the turn of the Common Era, with older narrative material [2], [3]. Its Critical Edition, prepared at the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute between 1933 and 1966, collated manuscripts across scripts and regions [21]. Only relative order matters here: the Vedic witnesses are older than the epic text.

Witzel's study of the Kuru state identifies the late Ṛgvedic and early post-Ṛgvedic Kuru realm as the setting of the epic and reads the *Mahābhārata* as a tale of conflict within the Kuru people, recited at the court of the post-war king [1]. That reading predicts exactly the kind of overlap tested here: Vedic attestation of the Kuru dynasty around the epic's frame. Sinha similarly reads the *Mahābhārata* as the *itihāsa* of the late-Vedic Kuru clan, tracing how a historical tradition was built from the Ṛgvedic battle of the ten kings to Kurukṣetra [17]. Both arguments are made by close reading rather than by a stated, repeatable test.

B. Historicity of Persons in Ancient Texts

The closest methodological model comes from biblical archaeology. Mykytiuk [6] formalised when a person named in the Hebrew Bible may be identified with a person named in a Northwest Semitic inscription. His criteria require (i) authentic data, (ii) a matching setting in time and place, and (iii) enough identifying marks—name, father's name, title, place, family—that the two cannot be different people. Identifications fall into six grades: S (certain, because singular circumstances require it), 3 (virtually certain to reliable), 2 (reasonable but uncertain), 1 (doubtful), 0 (no identification, lacking a clear basis) and D (disqualified) [6], [19]. Three matching marks with a fitting setting support grade 3, two support grade 2, and a name alone is never sufficient. Mykytiuk revised several cases after new discoveries and the exposure of forgeries [7]. His method uses inscriptions only. India has no deciphered inscriptions before Aśoka (third century BCE), so a direct application would identify nobody; the adaptation in this paper replaces the inscription with an older orally transmitted text and justifies that substitution with oral-tradition criticism.

Statistical arguments about named individuals in ancient sources have also been made from name frequencies, most prominently in Feuerverger's analysis of the Talpiot tomb [12], which drew extensive critical discussion. The present study uses name frequency only to weight evidence, not to assert identity.

C. Oral Tradition and Genealogies

Vansina's *Oral Tradition as History* [4] sets out how orally transmitted material can serve as historical evidence and how it changes in transmission. Henige's *The Chronology of Oral Tradition* [5] documents a specific failure mode of oral genealogies: real names are retained while relationships and sequences are merged, lengthened and re-ordered. Both shape this study: Vansina in judging the Vedic corpus as a witness, Henige in interpreting what the matches show about the epic's genealogies.

D. Record Linkage

Computerised record linkage began with Newcombe and colleagues' linkage of vital records [9]. Fellegi and Sunter [8] gave it a decision-theoretic foundation: each compared field contributes a log-likelihood ratio $\log(m/u)$, where m is the probability that the field agrees for a true match and u the probability that it agrees by chance; value-specific u lets rare values count more than common ones. Christen's monograph [10] and the review by Binette and Steorts [11] survey modern blocking, comparison, classification and evaluation practice, including precision–recall evaluation and clerical review, which this study adopts.

E. Gap

To the author's knowledge no prior study has matched the persons of the *Mahābhārata* against the Vedic corpus *systematically*—every person against every person—with a stated, pre-registered decision rule and validation tests. The nearest precedent is Raychaudhuri's *Political History of Ancient India* [16], which compared the epic and Vedic accounts of the Kuru kings by hand, arguing for instance that the Vedic Parikṣit corresponds to the epic's second Parikṣit. Other treatments (the Vedic Index's own notes [13], Witzel [1], Sinha [17]) likewise discuss selected kings. Computational work on the epic has modelled its characters only *inside* the text: Gultepe and Mathangi built character networks from word vectors and recovered the Pāṇḍava–Kaurava division [18], but did not test any character against external evidence. The present study is, to the author's knowledge, the first to combine these strands: a systematic, statistical and pre-registered comparison of the epic's people with an older, independent corpus.

III. Materials

A. The Epic Side

The epic dataset contains 107 people: the Kuru main line from Pratīpa to Śatānīka; the Pāṇḍavas, Kauravas and their allies; the Yādavas; the Pañcāla house; and the principal figures of the embedded stories (the Bharata, Purūravas, Yayāti and Māndhātṛ legends, the Uddālaka–Śvetaketu and Janaka–Yājñavalkya episodes, and others). For each person the father, mother, siblings, spouses, children, teachers or priests, people or dynasty, and a

TABLE I
STATED ASSUMPTIONS

	Assumption
A1	The Vedic texts as edited today are faithful to their early form (oral transmission with cross-checking recitations).
A2	The Vedic texts are older than the epic text.
A3	A king or priest named incidentally in a ritual text was a person of that period (identity then implies existence only to that extent).
A4	A shared name alone is not evidence: the epic's poets knew the Vedic texts.
A5	A patronymic names the legal father.
A6	The Vedic Index lists the persons of the Vedic texts with their key passages.
A7	Absence from the Vedic texts is not disproof: they are ritual, not historical, texts.

role class (royal, sage/priest, woman, other) were coded from the epic's own genealogies and episodes, chiefly Ādiparvan 1.57–1.90, *without consulting any Vedic match.* Indian naming practice is followed: a patronymic names the legal father (e.g., Dhṛtarāṣṭra is Vaicitravīrya, "son of Vicitravīrya").

B. The Vedic Side

Macdonell and Keith's *Vedic Index of Names and Subjects* [13] catalogues the persons, peoples, places and terms of the Vedic texts with their passages. Version 1 of this study parsed an optical-character-recognition (OCR) text of the 1912 scan; versions 2 and 3 use the Cologne Digital Sanskrit Lexicon transcription [14], which encodes 3,834 entries with marked headwords, diacritics and separated footnotes. Person records were selected automatically (a role word such as king, priest or teacher; a kinship word; or a patronymic in the headword), giving 2,051 records. For each record only the entry's own main text is used. **Every sentence that mentions the Epic, the Purāṇas, the Rāmāyaṇa, the Harivaṃśa or Pargiter is deleted**, because the Index often reports what the later tradition says and would otherwise leak the epic's genealogy into the supposedly independent witness.

IV. Method

A. Assumptions

Table I lists the assumptions on which a match's meaning depends. A4 and A7 are deliberately conservative: a shared name is never evidence, and absence is never disproof.

B. Pipeline

Fig. 1 summarises the procedure. Each step implements one published method.

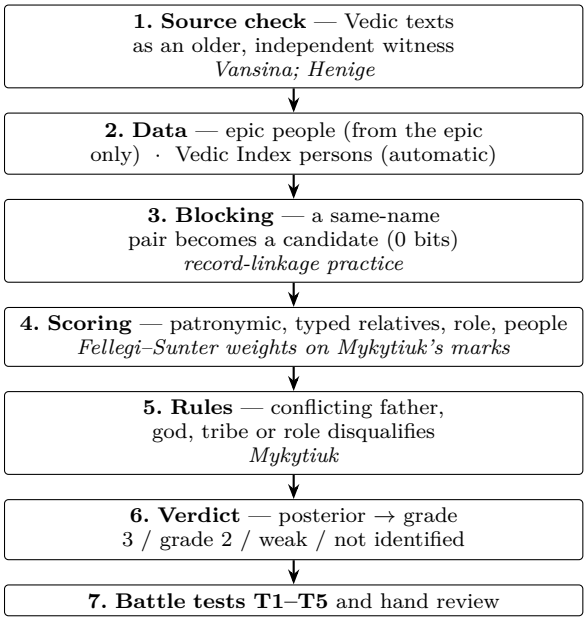


Fig. 1. The identification pipeline. Steps 1, 4 and 5 adapt published methods; step 7 is the validation design.

C. Scoring Model

Let an epic person e and a Vedic record v share a normalised name (transliteration- and OCR-insensitive; names shorter than four letters must match exactly). For each identifying mark k that is observed on both sides, the Fellegi–Sunter weight is

$$w_k = \begin{cases} \log_2 \dfrac{m_k}{u_k} & \text{if the mark agrees,} \\ \log_2 \dfrac{1-m_k}{1-u_k} & \text{if it conflicts,} \end{cases} \tag{1}$$

and the evidence is $W = \sum_k w_k$ bits. The name itself contributes nothing (A4). The marks are:

- **Patronymic.** The second element of the Vedic name must *begin* with the consonant skeleton of an epic parent's name, as Sanskrit patronymics are formed on the parent's name (Pārikṣita, Vaicitravīrya, Prātipīya); $m = 0.85$, $u = 0.01$. A patronymic matching no epic parent disqualifies.
- **Typed relatives and associates.** An epic relative's name counts only if it occurs within twelve words of a relation word of the *same type* (Table II); $m = 0.80$, and u is value-specific: the share of Vedic entries containing that name, with +1 smoothing and a floor of 0.001 [8].
- **Role** (royal, sage/priest, woman); $m = 0.90$, $u = 0.30$.
- **People or dynasty** named in the entry; $m = 0.90$, u frequency-based.

With prior odds π that a same-name candidate is the same person (main analysis $\pi = 1/10$, allowing for literary borrowing), the posterior probability of identity is

$$P(\text{same} \mid W) = \frac{\pi\, 2^W}{1 + \pi\, 2^W}. \tag{2}$$

Following Mykytiuk, $P \geq 0.95$ is grade 3, $P \geq 0.50$ grade 2, $P \geq 0.05$ "weak" (Mykytiuk's grade 1, doubtful), and below that "not identified" (grade 0); a disqualifying

TABLE II
RELATION WORDS REQUIRED FOR A TYPED RELATIVE (AMENDMENT 5)

Epic relation	Vedic wording that counts
Parent	son, daughter, descendant, father, mother, bore, patronymic
Child	son, daughter, father, mother, whose, his
Sibling	brother, brothers, sister
Spouse	wife, husband, queen, married, consort
Teacher/priest	priest, Purohita, pupil, teacher, taught, patron, officiated, sacrifice, court

rule gives grade D. Grade S is not used: no Vedic attestation is unique enough that singular circumstances force the identification. Each epic person takes its best candidate.

D. Disqualification Rules

R2 A Vedic patronymic that matches no epic parent.
R3 A Vedic namesake that is a god, demon or nymph where the epic has a human.
R6 A Vedic entry whose opening describes a tribe or people (version 3).
R7 Conflicting role classes on the two sides (version 3); Mykytiuk treats a conflicting mark as disqualifying.

E. Battle Tests

The protocol fixed five tests and their pass criteria before the first run:

T1 **Permutation null.** Relatives and parents are shuffled among epic people 1,000 times; the observed number of grade ≥ 2 matches must exceed the 99th percentile of the null.
T2 **False positives.** Every epic person is scored against every Vedic person *with a different name* (ignoring blocking); fewer than 1% of these wrong pairs may reach grade ≥ 2.
T3 **Known-identity recall.** Nine epic figures that standard scholarship identifies with Vedic figures (Bharata, Yayāti, Purūravas, Māndhātṛ, Nala, Uddālaka, Śvetaketu, Yājñavalkya, Janaka); at least six must reach grade ≥ 2.
T4 **Sensitivity.** Prior odds 1:3 and 1:30, and each m and u moved by $\pm 25\%$ (18 variants); a verdict is robust only if unchanged across all.
T5 **Clerical review.** Every grade ≥ 2 match and every disqualification is read against the Vedic text.

If T1, T2 or T3 failed, results were to be reported as exploratory only.

F. Pre-Registration and Amendments

The protocol and frozen datasets were committed to version control before scoring. Seven amendments followed, each committed with its reason (Table III); failed runs remain in the history. Amendments 4–5 and the version 3 rules were committed before the runs they govern.

TABLE III
AMENDMENTS TO THE PROTOCOL

#	Trigger	Change
1	First run	Entry text only; delete sentences about the Epic/Purāṇas (circularity); stricter blocking
2	T2 failed	Value-specific u (frequency weights); anusvāra normalisation
3	T2 diagnosis	Patronymic must *start* with the parent's skeleton; an entry cannot name itself
4	v1 precision 0.62	Clean Cologne transcription replaces OCR
5	v1 precision 0.62	Typed relationships (Table II)
6	v2 parse check	Kinship words also mark a person record
v3	v2 review	R6 tribe rule; R7 role-conflict rule
7	CE check	Somaka's father and Arjuna's son corrected (data only)

TABLE IV
BATTLE-TEST RESULTS BY VERSION

Test (pass criterion)	v1	v2	v3
T1 observed / null 99th pct.	24 / 13	26 / 12	**21 / 9**
T1 p	0.001	0.001	**0.001**
T2 false-positive rate ($< 1\%$)	1.30%	0.60%	**0.48%**
T2 wrong-name pairs	207,801	219,343	219,343
T3 known identities ($\geq 6/9$)	6	7	**7**
T5 precision	0.62	0.71	**0.76**
T5 recall	0.83	0.83	**0.84**
T5 identity-only precision	—	—	**0.95**
Verdict	fail	pass	**pass**

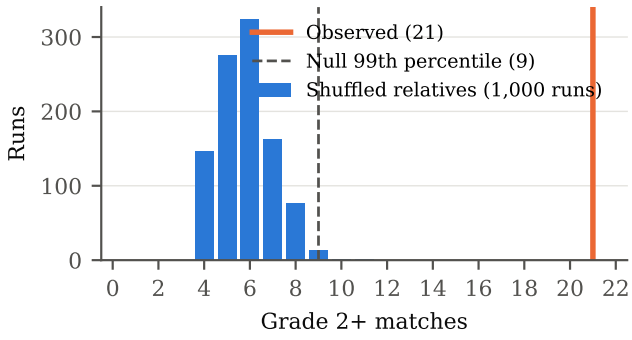


Fig. 2. T1 permutation test, version 3. Bars: number of grade ≥ 2 matches in each of 1,000 runs with relatives shuffled among epic people. Line: the observed count with the true relatives.

V. RESULTS

A. Battle Tests

Table IV reports the three versions. Version 1 failed T2. Versions 2 and 3 pass T1, T2 and T3. Fig. 2 shows the version 3 permutation null: 21 observed matches against a null mean of 5.8, a 99th percentile of 9 and a maximum of 11 in 1,000 shuffles ($p = 0.001$). Fig. 3 shows the false-positive rate and agreement with the hand review across versions.

Errors that remain: Of the 21 version 3 matches, 16 agree with the hand review. Four of the five disagreements are correct identities of figures the Vedic texts treat as legendary or as a family name (Purūravas, Yayāti,

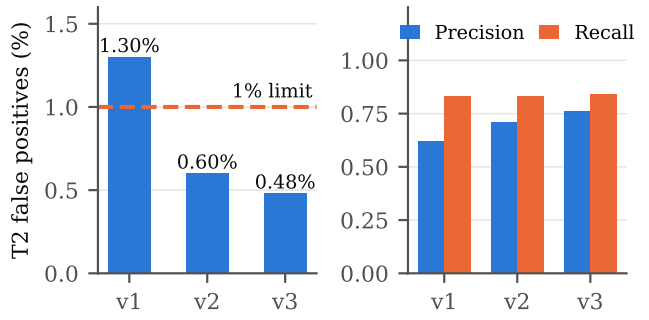


Fig. 3. Left: T2 false-positive rate by version against the pre-set 1% limit. Right: precision and recall against the hand review.

Viśvāmitra, Vasiṣṭha); counting identity alone, 20 of 21 are right. The single true error (Kuru) is a parsing slip in which the entry Kuruśravaṇa was read as "Kuru". Three hand-confirmed links are missed (Parikṣit, Yājñavalkya, Kalmāṣapāda) because the relation is stated in another entry or sentence. T4 flags 28 of the 107 automatic verdicts as sensitive to the prior or to a ±25% parameter shift; the hand review therefore decides the final grades.

B. Critical Edition Check of the Epic Side

Every epic relationship on which a verdict depends was checked against the BORI Critical Edition electronic text [20], [21] (Table V). Two coding errors were found and corrected (Amendment 7): the Critical Edition does not make Somaka the son of Sahadeva—the two are only listed together at 3.125.23, the filiation coming from the Purāṇas—and Arjuna's son by Draupadī is Śrutakīrti. The first correction lowered Somaka from grade 3 to grade 2. The check also strengthened one case: the epic's Baka Dālbhya episode names Dhṛtarāṣṭra *vaicitravīryin* (9.40.1), the same patronymic as the Vedic record in the same quarrel.

C. Second Review and Inter-Rater Agreement

To address the single-reviewer threat, a second reviewer judged 61 people blind: it received only the epic record and the candidate Vedic entries, in shuffled order, with no automatic scores and no first-review verdicts, and applied the same categories. The second reviewer was an AI model run separately from the analysis; a human Sanskritist review remains the recommended next step. On the 37 people both reviewed (Table VI), the reviewers agreed on every identity decision. All five category disagreements concern whether a correctly identified figure is historical or legendary (Vyāsa, Kalmāṣapāda, Vasiṣṭha, Yayāti, Viśvāmitra), and all five grade disagreements are grade 3 versus grade 2, the second reviewer being stricter each time. Disagreements were adjudicated conservatively: the lower grade, or "same figure, historicity disputed".

TABLE V
Epic Relationships Checked Against the Critical Edition

Relationship	CE	OK?
Janamejaya, son of Parikṣit; brothers Śrutasena, Ugrasena, Bhīmasena	1.3.1	yes
Janamejaya's son Śatānīka by Vapuṣṭamā	1.90.94	yes
Pratīpa (Paryaśravas), son of Bhīmasena; sons Devāpi, Śaṃtanu, Bāhlīka	1.90.44–46	yes
Parikṣit, son of Abhimanyu	1.36.17	yes
Dhṛtarāṣṭra born in the field of Vicitravīrya	1.57.95	yes
Bharata, son of Duḥṣanta and Śakuntalā	1.89.16	yes
Yayāti, son of Nahuṣa; Purūravas, son of Ilā	1.84.1; 1.70.16	yes
Śakti, son of Vasiṣṭha, eaten by Kalmāṣapāda	1.166.4–36	yes
Āruṇi Pāñcālya; Śvetaketu Auddālaki	1.3.20; 3.132.1	yes
Māndhātṛ Yauvanāśva	3.126.1	yes
Indrota Śaunaka and Janamejaya	12.146–148	yes
Drupada = Yajñasena; Śikhaṇḍin, child of Drupada	1.122.26; 1.57.104	yes
Baka Dālbhya and Dhṛtarāṣṭra *vaicitravīryin*	9.40.1	yes
Somaka, son of Sahadeva	3.125.23	**no**[a]
Arjuna's son by Draupadī is Śrutakīrti	1.90.82	fixed[b]

[a] Only listed together; the filiation is Purāṇic. Somaka lowered to grade 2. [b] Coding error corrected; no verdict affected.

TABLE VI
Agreement Between the Two Reviews ($n = 37$)

Level	Agree	κ	Reading
Same person? (accept/reject)	37/37	1.00	perfect
Identified / legendary / not	32/37	0.77	substantial
Exact grade	22/37	0.52	moderate

D. Identifications

Table VII gives the adjudicated verdicts; Fig. 4 the evidence for the automatic matches.

VI. Discussion

A. An Asymmetric Record

The attestations are not spread evenly over the epic's family tree. They concentrate in three places.

The post-war court is securely attested. Janamejaya Pārikṣita is the strongest identification in the study and matches on six independent marks, including an entire episode: in both the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa and the *Mahābhārata*, the priest Indrota performs a horse sacrifice to cleanse Janamejaya of killing a Brahmin. Witzel's reading of the epic as recited at the court of the post-war Kuru king [1] is consistent with this result.

The pre-war genealogy is real material rearranged. Bālhika, Śaṃtanu and Devāpi are real Vedic names, but the relationships the epic gives them conflict with the Vedic record: Devāpi's father is Ṛṣṭiṣeṇa, not Pratīpa, and the Ṛgveda shows Devāpi as Śaṃtanu's priest with "no hint of relationship" [13]. Śatānīka is a real

TABLE VII
ADJUDICATED IDENTIFICATIONS OF *MAHĀBHĀRATA* PEOPLE IN THE VEDIC CORPUS (TWO REVIEWERS; CONSERVATIVE ADJUDICATION)

Epic person	Vedic person (source)	Matching marks	Verdict
Janamejaya	Janamejaya Pārikṣita (ŚB 13.5.4; AB 8.21)	Father Parikṣit; brothers Ugrasena, Bhīmasena, Śrutasena; priest Indrota; same expiation episode (ŚB 13.5.4.1 / *Mahābhārata* 12.146–148)	Grade 3
Ugrasena	Ugrasena Pārikṣitīya (ŚB 13.5.4.3)	Brother of Janamejaya, with Bhīmasena and Śrutasena	Grade 3
Indrota Śaunaka	Indrota Daivāpa Śaunaka (ŚB 13.5.4.1)	Janamejaya's priest in the same episode	Grade 3
Uddālaka; Śvetaketu	Uddālaka Āruṇi; Śvetaketu Āruṇeya	Father and son; Pañcāla setting	Grade 3
Janaka	Janaka of Videha	Patron of Yājñavalkya	Grade 3
Śakti	Śakti (Jaiminīya Br.)	Son of Vasiṣṭha; killed at the instigation of the Viśvāmitras	Grade 3
Śrutasena (and Bhīmasena)	The Pārikṣitīyas (ŚB 13.5.4.3)	Brothers of Janamejaya	Grade 2
Bālhika	Bālhika Prātipīya (ŚB 12.9.3.3)	Son of Pratīpa; Kuru king	Grade 2
Bharata	Bharata Dauḥṣanti (ŚB 13.5.4.11–14)	Son of Duḥṣanta; mother Śakuntalā	Grade 2
Māndhātṛ	Māndhātṛ Yauvanāśva	Son of Yuvanāśva; king	Grade 2
Yājñavalkya	Yājñavalkya	Teacher at Janaka's court	Grade 2
Somaka	Somaka Sāhadevya (ṚV 4.15)	King; Sahadeva named with him in both (filiation not in the CE)	Grade 2
Parikṣit	Parikṣit (AV 20.127.7–10)	Kuru king; son Janamejaya. Some read the hymn as about Agni	Grade 2
Dhṛtarāṣṭra	Dhṛtarāṣṭra Vaicitravīrya (Kāṭhaka S.)	Same patronymic in the same Baka/Vaka Dālbhya quarrel (CE 9.40.1); possibly not a Kuru	Grade 2
Śaṃtanu	Śaṃtanu (ṚV 10.98; Nirukta 2.10)	With Devāpi as priest; brotherhood only in the Nirukta	Grade 2
Kṛṣṇa	Kṛṣṇa Devakīputra (ChU 3.17.6)	Mother Devakī; a pupil, no royal context	Grade 2
Vyāsa; Yayāti; Viśvāmitra; Vasiṣṭha; Kalmāṣapāda	Vyāsa Pārāśarya; Yayāti Nāhuṣa; Viśvāmitra; Vasiṣṭha; the Saudāsas	Same figures; reviewers split on historical vs legendary	Same figure, historicity disputed
Purūravas; Śakuntalā	Purūravas Aila; Śakuntalā	Same figures; mythical or a nymph in the Vedic texts	Same figure, legendary
Devāpi	Devāpi Ārṣṭiṣeṇa (ṚV 10.98)	Vedic father Ṛṣṭiṣeṇa, epic father Pratīpa	D
Śatānīka	Śatānīka Sātrājita (ŚB 13.5.4.19)	Vedic father Satrājit, epic father Janamejaya	D
Pratīpa	Pratīpa Prātisatvana (AV Khila)	Different patronymic; possibly not a name	D
Śikhaṇḍin; Śakuni	Śikhaṇḍin Yājñasena; Saubala	Patronymic matches but a priest / a pupil	D (role)
Yadu; Pūru	Tribes (ṚV)	Rigvedic tribes; the epic makes them brothers	Tribe, not person
Bhīṣma, Pāṇḍu, Kuntī, Mādrī, Gāndhārī, Draupadī, Drupada, Dhṛṣṭadyumna, the five Pāṇḍavas, Duryodhana, Duḥśāsana, Karṇa, Droṇa, Aśvatthāman, Kṛpa, Abhimanyu, Vidura, Satyavatī, Jarāsandha, Śiśupāla, Virāṭa, Śalya, Ghaṭotkaca and others			0 (no attestation)

king but not Janamejaya's son. Rigvedic tribes (Yadu, Pūru, Turvaśa, Druhyu) become the sons of Yayāti. This is the pattern Henige documents for oral genealogies: names survive, relationships are merged and re-ordered [5].

The embedded stories rest on Vedic figures. Uddālaka, Śvetaketu, Janaka and Śakti are identified at grade 3, and Bharata Dauḥṣanti, Somaka, Māndhātṛ Yauvanāśva and Yājñavalkya at grade 2, several with father and associates. The epic drew its side narratives from a known stock of Vedic persons and legends.

B. The Silent Centre

No member of the war generation—on either side—has an independent Vedic attestation. Under A7 this is not disproof: the Brāhmaṇas are ritual manuals and may simply not mention them. But the silence is consistent, it falls precisely on the generation the epic is about, and it contrasts with the attestation of the generations before and after. The finding parallels other ancient epics in which a real place or dynasty frames heroes known only from the poem.

C. What the Method Contributes

Two lessons generalise beyond this corpus. First, *relationship type matters more than co-occurrence*: typed relations halved the false-positive rate (1.30%→0.60%) and raised precision. Second, *circularity is the main threat in historical linkage*: a reference work that reports a later tradition can leak that tradition into the "independent" evidence, and must be filtered before scoring.

VII. THREATS TO VALIDITY

- **Reviewers.** Two reviews agree on every identity ($\kappa = 1.00$), but the second reviewer was an AI model, not a human Sanskritist. A human expert review of the 37 adjudicated cases is the most important next step.

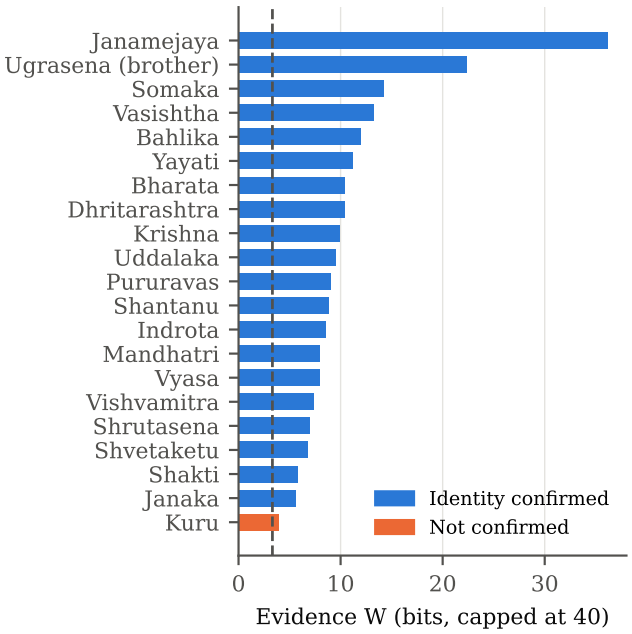


Fig. 4. Evidence (Fellegi–Sunter bits) for every automatic grade ≥ 2 match in version 3, coloured by the hand review: confirmed identity versus not confirmed. The dashed line is the grade-2 threshold at prior odds 1:10 ($W = \log_2 10 \approx 3.3$ bits).

- **Epic side.** Coded by one person; every relationship on which a verdict depends was checked against the Critical Edition (Table V), but the remaining relationships were not.
- **Not a blind test.** The author had seen a small hand-made register before the full run. Parameters were not changed after the protocol, but the amendments were made in response to results; all are recorded.
- **Identity, not existence.** A match shows the epic's person is the Vedic person. For Brāhmaṇa-period kings the Vedic attestation is close to contemporary; for Ṛgvedic figures it may itself be legendary (A3).
- **Coverage.** The Vedic Index is a 1912 reference work. Persons it omits cannot be found; Nala was not recovered. Using the primary Vedic texts directly would extend coverage.
- **Borrowing.** The epic's poets knew the Vedic texts. The method never counts a name, but borrowing of a name together with its relations cannot be excluded.

VIII. Conclusion

A pre-registered, battle-tested record-linkage method identifies seven people of the *Mahābhārata* with Vedic persons at grade 3 and eleven more at grade 2, with two reviewers agreeing on every identity. The results support a precise statement: the *Mahābhārata* is framed around a real late-Vedic Kuru court and draws on real Vedic figures, but it re-arranges their relationships, and its central war heroes cannot be found outside the epic. The method, data and failures are documented so that the result can be checked, contested and extended—to the Purāṇic king lists, to the Rāmāyaṇa, and to the later question of dating.

Data and Code Availability

The epic dataset, all scripts, the protocol with its seven amendments, the battle-test outputs, both reviews and the adjudicated verdicts are released under CC BY 4.0 (code: MIT) on Zenodo, doi: 10.5281/zenodo.23875710 [15]. Third-party texts are not redistributed; a script downloads them and verifies their checksums. The Vedic Index transcription is from the Cologne Digital Sanskrit Lexicon [14].

Use of AI Tools

An AI assistant (Claude, Anthropic) was used to write analysis code, retrieve and check references, and draft text under the author's direction. The author defined the research question, reviewed every identification, and takes full responsibility for the content.

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